



ARROWS OF GOLD

Sheetal Devi became the first woman without arms to win a gold medal at the World Archery Para Championships, defeating Turkiye's Oznur Cure Girdi in the Women's Compound Open final in Korea. The teenage Paralympian took the lead in the second end of the gold medal match and held her nerve to close out a 146-143 win over the three-time world champion and reigning Paris 2024 Paralympics gold medallist.

The individual final was tense, but Sheetal shot with remarkable composure. The opening end was tied at 29-all before she fired three 10s to take the second end 30-27. The third end was also shared at 29-all. Her only lapse came in the fourth, where she scored 28 as Girdi edged it by a point, though Sheetal still retained a two-point advantage at 116-114. She then sealed her maiden world title with a flawless final end, hitting three perfect arrows for 30.

The gold capped a memorable day for Sheetal, who also won silver and bronze in the team events. Her performances through the season also led to another milestone, as she became the first Indian para-archer to be selected for an able-bodied international competition after being named in the national squad for the Asia Cup in Jeddah, Saudi Arabia. Born without arms, Sheetal had long dreamt of competing alongside able-bodied archers, a goal the 18-year-old realised through persistence, precision, and belief.

PATIENCE REWARDED

Joe Root's long wait for an Ashes century in Australia finally ended with a sublime hundred in the second Test in Brisbane. After crossing fifty 29 times Down Under without converting, Root reached three figures with a delicate flick to fine leg, pausing to savour a moment that had long eluded him. His struggles in Australian conditions had fuelled criticism and earned him the unfair tag of "Average Joe", despite his stature as one of the game's greats. Root silenced those doubts with a masterful unbeaten 138 off 206 balls, rescuing England from 5 for 2 and steering it to a competitive 334 in the first innings. The innings also underlined his seamless adaptation to England's aggressive 'Bazball' era, which has revived his output. Since the summer of 2022, Root has been the leading run-scorer in Test cricket, amassing over 4,000 runs at an average north of 53. His resurgence has placed him within touching distance of Sachin Tendulkar's all-time Test run record.

